



PUBLIC MANIFESTO + OPERATING PRINCIPLES

The Work Should Feel Alive

A different kind of nonprofit is possible.

“We can do serious research and work.
And live joyfully.”

A NONPROFIT SHOULD MAKE LIFE LARGER

We are here to teach people how to play again.

Not because the work is small. Because it is enormous - and people deserve a way into it that does not require them to disappear inside the mission.

We believe people can do serious research and work. And live joyfully.

Too much service is built on guilt, exhaustion, and the idea that caring more should hurt more. We reject that bargain. Joy is not what happens after the work is finished. Joy is part of how good work stays honest, human, and alive.

The most important problems on Earth should also become the most meaningful game people can play together.

That game has real stakes. It asks us to observe closely, test what we think we know, repair what has been damaged, and build conditions in which life can thrive. Nobody has to be everything. Everybody can tend something real.

We will show our work, name what failed, protect what is vulnerable, and change course when evidence asks us to. Disagreement is information. Relationship is infrastructure. The garden keeps the books.

NOT A FORTRESS. A GARDEN. A living place can welcome difference and still protect the life inside. The Ark was never a boat. It is a way of keeping life moving. We begin where we are, learn what we can, and share what works so others can carry it farther.

THE INVITATION

Come with what you know, what you wonder, and what you can tend. Read. Question. Research. Build. Volunteer. Teach. Learn. Bring your own intelligence, and leave room for someone else's. Help make the future more alive than the present.

JOY BECOMES REAL THROUGH PRACTICE

How we make the promise operational

A beautiful manifesto is not enough. These are the habits that keep the work from turning into the kind of institution we are trying to change.

01

Life is the measure.

Every project begins with a plain question: does this protect or increase the capacity for life?

- Name who or what should benefit before work begins.
- Look for harm, extraction, and burdens pushed onto someone else.
- Set a stop condition when the cost becomes larger than the good.
- Measure what remains useful across generations, not only what looks impressive today.

02

Joy is infrastructure.

We do not use suffering as proof of commitment. A mission that consumes its people is eating its own future.

- Make room for humor, curiosity, beauty, rest, and celebration inside the work.
- Design roles people can sustain, not heroic workloads they must survive.
- Treat “no,” “not now,” and “I need help” as useful information.
- Notice when the work has stopped feeling alive - and change the conditions.

03

Play means real agency.

Play is not decoration. It is the freedom to enter, explore, choose a role, see feedback, and try again.

- Offer clear ways to witness, learn, tend, test, build, and lead.
- Give people real work with visible outcomes, not busywork dressed as participation.
- Let contributors change roles as their interests and capacities change.
- Credit the people whose hands and minds moved the work forward.

04

Research stays honest.

Wonder is welcome. Claims still have to earn their weight.

- Separate observation, pattern, hypothesis, evidence, result, and unknown.
- Publish methods and corrections, not only victories.
- Keep stories and symbols without presenting them as measured facts.
- Let “we do not know yet” remain a responsible answer.

DESTRUCTION IS EASY. CULTIVATION IS REMEMBRANCE.

THE INSTITUTION SERVES THE LIFE INSIDE IT

Power, relationship, and money stay visible

05

Stewards, not rulers.

Leadership is a responsibility held for a purpose, not a throne someone owns.

- Make authority specific: what decision, for how long, with what limits.
- Return power when the need has passed.
- Record consequential decisions and who carries the consequences.
- Build so no person, funder, platform, or artificial intelligence becomes indispensable to the whole.

THE CENTER MAY BE OCCUPIED. IT MAY NEVER BE OWNED.

06

Relationship is infrastructure.

How people are treated is not separate from the mission. It is the mission made visible.

- Set expectations clearly and repair harm directly.
- Do not hide paid labor inside an endless volunteer ask.
- Respect consent, capacity, privacy, and the right to step away.
- Make collaboration possible without demanding sameness.

07

Disagreement is information.

We do not vote the outlier out of the room just because agreement feels cleaner.

- Ask what evidence the disagreement rests on.
- Name what would change each person's mind.
- Record unresolved questions instead of manufacturing consensus.
- Protect the right to challenge a plan without punishing the person who spoke.

08

The garden keeps the books.

Trust does not replace accounting. It makes honest accounting non-negotiable.

- Use clear budgets, approvals, records, and conflict disclosures.
- Keep nonprofit and business funds, contracts, books, and intellectual-property arrangements distinct.
- Tell funders and participants what money can and cannot do.
- Count value created for life, not just money raised or activity completed.

PROOF TRAVELS FARTHER THAN PROMISES

Build small enough to learn. Share well enough to spread.

09

Protection is quiet and real.

Openness does not mean leaving people, animals, places, or knowledge available for extraction.

- Collect only the information the work truly needs.
- Set boundaries before a crisis, not after damage is done.
- Protect vulnerable participants without making fear the culture.
- Design safety so people inside can keep living joyfully.

10

Grow by proof, not performance.

Begin at a scale where people can observe the whole system, learn honestly, and correct it.

- Pilot before promising scale.
- Document enough that another person can understand what happened.
- Make each part able to stand on its own.
- State clearly what is public, licensed, private, unfinished, or still uncertain.
- Share what works so others can adapt it without needing permission to care.

If we are succeeding, people will be able to feel it.

Staff will know why their work matters, what “done” looks like, and when they are allowed to stop. Volunteers will be able to enter without deciphering the institution first. Researchers will be able to inspect the method. Funders will see the truth, including the limits. Disagreement will improve the plan or remain visible. Nobody will have to surrender dignity to belong.

A LIVING STANDARD, NOT A FINISHED RULEBOOK

The questions we keep asking

The work will change. These questions keep its center honest while it grows.

Did we protect or increase life?

What did we learn that changed us?

Did joy survive the way we worked?

Who carried too much weight?

What became easier for the next person?

What should we stop doing?

We want other nonprofit employees to look at this work and ask:

Why can't we do this too?

And we want the answer to be simple:

You can. Take what helps. Change what does not. Build your own garden. Keep life moving.